



Graduate Syllabus: Christian Mysticism, Theology, and Church History (Catholic & Orthodox)

Duration: 1 Year (52 weeks)

Approach: Textual + Historical + Philosophical Integration

Week	Christian Text / Theme	Philosophical Companion	Historical Context / Secondary Source	Seminar Focus
1	New Testament (John 1–3; Romans 8; 2 Pet 1) — deification and Logos	Plato, <i>Republic</i> VI–VII; <i>Phaedrus</i>	Pelikan, <i>The Christian Tradition</i> , vol. 1 ch.1–2	The Logos and divine participation: philosophy enters theology
2	Apostolic Fathers (Ignatius, Clement, Didache)	Plato, <i>Symposium</i>	Chadwick, <i>The Early Church</i> , ch.1–3	The Church as mystical body under persecution
3	Origen, <i>On Prayer; Commentary on the Song of Songs</i>	Philo, <i>On the Creation of the World</i>	Daniélou, <i>The Theology of Jewish Christianity</i>	Alexandrian allegory and contemplative exegesis
4	Athanasius, <i>Life of Antony</i>	Aristotle, <i>Nicomachean Ethics</i> X	Brown, <i>The Body and Society</i> , ch.2	Desert monasticism and ascetic mysticism
5	Cappadocian Fathers: Gregory of Nyssa, <i>Life of Moses</i>	Plato, <i>Parmenides</i>	Grillmeier, <i>Christ in Christian Tradition</i> , vol. 1	Trinity, apophaticism, and Nicene orthodoxy
6	Pseudo-Dionysius, <i>Mystical Theology</i>	Proclus, <i>Elements of Theology</i>	Louth, <i>Denys the Areopagite</i> ; Chalcedon (451)	The Neoplatonization of Christian theology
7	John Cassian, <i>Conferences</i>	Aristotle, <i>De Anima</i> III	Rousseau, <i>Ascetics, Authority, and the Church</i>	Western monastic theology and grace
8	Maximus the Confessor, <i>Ambigua</i>	Plotinus, <i>Enneads</i> V.1, V.2	Meyendorff, <i>Byzantine Theology</i> ch.1–2	Cosmic Christology and the Monothelite crisis
9	John of Damascus, <i>Exposition of the Orthodox Faith</i>	Aristotle, <i>Metaphysics</i> XII	Pelikan, <i>The Spirit of Eastern Christendom</i>	Icons, incarnation, and the 7th Ecumenical Council
10	Symeon the New Theologian, <i>Hymns of Divine Love</i>	Plotinus, <i>Enneads</i> VI.7	Ware, <i>The Orthodox Way</i> , ch.2	Byzantine mystical renewal and experiential theology
11	Gregory Palamas, <i>Triads</i>	Aristotle, <i>Metaphysics</i> V; Proclus on participation	Meyendorff, <i>A Study of Gregory Palamas</i>	Hesychasm, theosis, and the Palamite controversy
12	The <i>Philokalia</i> (Vol. 1)	Iamblichus, <i>On</i>	Schmemmann, <i>For the</i>	Prayer of the heart and

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	selections)	<i>the Mysteries</i>	<i>Life of the World</i>	the theology of silence
13	John Scotus Eriugena, <i>Periphyseon</i>	Proclus, <i>Elements of Theology</i>	Marenbon, <i>Early Medieval Philosophy (480–1150)</i>	Western Neoplatonism and the Carolingian renaissance
14	Anselm, <i>Proslogion</i> ; <i>Monologion</i>	Aristotle, <i>Posterior Analytics</i> II	Southern, <i>Saint Anselm: A Portrait in a Landscape</i>	Faith seeking understanding after the Gregorian Reform
15	Hugh of St Victor, <i>Didascalicon</i>	Plato, <i>Phaedrus</i>	Leclercq, <i>The Love of Learning and the Desire for God</i>	Monastic learning and the medieval schools
16	Richard of St Victor, <i>Benjamin Major</i>	Plotinus, <i>Enneads</i> V.3	McGinn, <i>The Growth of Mysticism</i> , ch.5	Psychology of contemplation in the twelfth century
17	Bernard of Clairvaux, <i>On Loving God</i>	Plato, <i>Symposium</i> (eros–agape)	Radding & Newton, <i>Theology, Rhetoric, and Politics in the Twelfth Century</i>	Love mysticism and reform of monastic culture
18	Bonaventure, <i>Itinerarium Mentis in Deum</i>	Proclus on <i>epistrophē</i> ; Augustine’s illumination	Hayes, <i>Bonaventure: Mystical Theologian</i>	Franciscan mysticism and affective theology
19	Thomas Aquinas, <i>Summa Theologiae</i> (Ia-IIae qq.1–5; I q.12)	Aristotle, <i>Metaphysics</i> XII; <i>De Anima</i> III	Torrell, <i>Aquinas: The Mind of the Theologian</i>	Grace, intellect, and the beatific vision
20	Meister Eckhart, <i>Sermons</i>	Plotinus, <i>Enneads</i> VI.9	McGinn, <i>The Mystical Thought of Meister Eckhart</i>	“The Ground”: mystical identity and being
21	The <i>Cloud of Unknowing</i>	Dionysius & Proclus on apophasis	Underhill, <i>Mysticism</i> , ch.6–8	The anonymous mystic and negative theology
22	Julian of Norwich, <i>Revelations of Divine Love</i>	Plato, <i>Timaeus</i>	Jantzen, <i>Julian of Norwich: Mystic and Theologian</i>	Optimism, sin, and divine motherhood
23	Catherine of Siena, <i>Dialogue</i>	Aristotle, <i>Ethics</i> VIII–IX	Noffke, <i>Catherine of Siena: Vision Through a Distant Eye</i>	Mystical love and political theology
24	Thomas à Kempis, <i>Imitation of Christ</i>	Aristotle on habit; Evagrius on <i>praktike</i>	McDonnell, <i>The Imitation of Christ: A Spiritual Classic</i>	Interior imitation and humility
25	John of the Cross, <i>Dark Night of the Soul</i>	Plotinus, <i>Enneads</i> I.2	Peers, <i>Spirit of Flame</i>	Purification, negation, and union
26	Teresa of Ávila, <i>Interior Castle</i>	Plato, <i>Philebus</i>	Williams, <i>Teresa of Ávila</i>	Inner life and ordered joy
27	Francis de Sales, <i>Treatise on the Love of God</i>	Aristotle, <i>Ethics</i> X	Wright, <i>Heart Speaks to Heart</i>	Everyday holiness and contemplation

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28	Seraphim of Sarov, <i>Conversation with Motovilov</i>	Palamite energies vs Plotinian emanation	Zenkovsky, <i>A History of Russian Philosophy</i>	The Russian hesychast revival
29	Pascal, <i>Pensées</i>	Augustine, <i>Confessions</i> (revisited)	Goldmann, <i>The Hidden God</i>	Faith, paradox, and modernity
30	Nicodemus the Hagiorite, <i>Unseen Warfare</i>	Iamblichus on theurgy	Colliander, <i>Way of the Ascetics</i>	Spiritual combat in modern Orthodoxy
31	Eastern liturgical theology (Schmemmann)	Plato, <i>Statesman</i>	Taft, <i>Beyond East and West</i>	Liturgy and ontology
32	Thérèse of Lisieux, <i>Story of a Soul</i>	Plato, <i>Crito</i> & <i>Phaedo</i>	von Balthasar, <i>Two Sisters in the Spirit</i>	The little way and mystical obedience
33	Edith Stein, <i>Science of the Cross</i>	Husserl, <i>Ideas I</i> §§1–47	Borden, <i>Edith Stein: Philosopher and Mystic</i>	Phenomenology and Carmelite mysticism
34	Silouan the Athonite, <i>Writings</i>	Plotinus, <i>Enneads</i> V.3	Sophrony, <i>Saint Silouan the Athonite</i>	Humility as mystical knowledge
35	Henri de Lubac, <i>Catholicism</i>	Participation: Plato–Aquinas–de Lubac	Nichols, <i>From Newman to Congar</i>	Ressourcement and the return to the Fathers
36	Vladimir Lossky, <i>Mystical Theology of the Eastern Church</i>	Aristotle, <i>Metaphysics</i> IX (act and potency)	Florovsky, <i>Ways of Russian Theology</i>	Theosis and apophatic ontology
37	Thomas Merton, <i>New Seeds of Contemplation</i>	Plotinus, <i>Enneads</i> I.6	Shannon, <i>Silent Lamp</i>	Contemplation in the modern West
38	Olivier Clément, <i>Roots of Christian Mysticism</i>	Proclus–Dionysius lineage study	Ware, <i>The Inner Kingdom</i>	Reclaiming the patristic inheritance
39	John Paul II, <i>Crossing the Threshold of Hope</i>	Aristotle, <i>Politics</i> I (human teleology)	Nichols, <i>Rome and the Eastern Churches</i>	The mystical person in modern theology
40	Jean Corbon, <i>The Wellspring of Worship</i>	Plato, <i>Timaeus</i>	Taft, <i>Beyond East and West</i>	Liturgy as cosmic mediation
41	Dumitru Stăniloae, <i>Orthodox Dogmatic Theology</i> I	Proclus on participation	Louth, <i>Modern Orthodox Thinkers</i>	Essence and energies re-examined
42	Hans Urs von Balthasar, <i>Glory of the Lord</i> I	Plato, <i>Hippias Major</i> ; Plotinus I.6	Kilby, <i>Balthasar: A (Very) Critical Introduction</i>	Beauty as revelation
43	David Bentley Hart, <i>The Beauty of the Infinite</i>	Plato's <i>Good</i> → Trinity	Coakley, <i>God, Sexuality, and the Self</i>	Aesthetic theology and apophasis
44	Comparative: Palamas and Aquinas	Aristotle, <i>Metaphysics</i> IX	Cross, <i>The Metaphysics of Theosis</i>	Act, energy, and participation
45	Comparative: Dionysius & Eckhart	Proclus, <i>Elements</i> (later props.)	McGinn, <i>Presence of God</i> , vol. 4	Negative theology East and West

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46	Comparative: Maximus & John of the Cross	Plotinus, <i>Enneads</i> V.1, VI.9	Reore, <i>Pseudo-Dionysius: A Commentary</i>	Deification and mystical ascent
47	Comparative: Lossky & Balthasar	Plato, <i>Republic</i> VI	von Balthasar, <i>Theo-Drama</i> vol. 1	Beauty, love, and divine life
48	Schmemmann & Merton (Liturgy & Contemplation)	Aristotle, <i>Ethics</i> X	Bouyer, <i>Meaning of the Monastic Life</i>	Contemplative praxis and the world
49	<i>Philokalia</i> & <i>Cloud of Unknowing</i> (paired)	Dionysius & Proclus	McGinn, <i>Presence of God</i> , vol. 1–2	East–West apophatic parallels
50	Maximus & John of the Cross (paired)	Plotinus, <i>Enneads</i> V.9	Thunberg, <i>Microcosm and Mediator</i>	Theosis as metaphysical ascent
51	Lossky & Balthasar (paired)	Plato's <i>Good</i> vs <i>Beauty</i>	Hart, <i>The Experience of God</i>	The glory of the Good
52	Schmemmann, <i>For the Life of the World</i> (revisited)	Aristotle on <i>praxis/theoria</i>	Ratzinger, <i>Spirit of the Liturgy</i>	Liturgy as eschatological contemplation

Absolutely — here's the full graduate-level bibliography corresponding to your **Christian Mysticism, Theology, and Church History** syllabus, including primary, secondary, and historical/contextual sources.

It's organized by **category** (Primary Christian, Philosophical, Historical/Secondary) and then **chronologically within each**, to reflect how they fit across the 52-week plan.



Comprehensive Bibliography

For: Graduate Syllabus in Christian Mysticism, Theology & Church History (Catholic & Orthodox)

Scope: Mystical theology, philosophical background, Church history, and major secondary scholarship.

I. PRIMARY CHRISTIAN SOURCES

Scripture and Early Christianity

- The Holy Bible — RSV or NRSV, with Apocrypha (Oxford Annotated Edition)
- *Didache* and *Letters of Ignatius of Antioch* (Penguin Classics)
- *The Apostolic Fathers*, ed. Bart D. Ehrman, Loeb Classical Library, 2003
- Justin Martyr, *First Apology*
- Irenaeus of Lyons, *Against Heresies*, trans. Dominic J. Unger (Newman Press, 1992)

Greek Fathers and Desert Tradition

- Origen, *On Prayer and Commentary on the Song of Songs*, trans. Rowan Greer (Paulist Press, *Classics of Western Spirituality* series)
- Athanasius, *Life of Antony* (Penguin Classics)
- *Sayings of the Desert Fathers*, trans. Benedicta Ward (Cistercian Publications)
- Evagrius Ponticus, *Praktikos and Chapters on Prayer*, trans. John Eudes Bamberger (Cistercian Publications)
- Gregory of Nyssa, *The Life of Moses*, trans. Abraham Malherbe & Everett Ferguson (Paulist Press)
- Pseudo-Dionysius the Areopagite, *The Complete Works*, trans. Colm Luibheid (Paulist Press)
- Maximus the Confessor, *Ambigua*, trans. Nicholas Constas (Harvard UP, *Dumbarton Oaks Medieval Library*, 2014)
- John Climacus, *The Ladder of Divine Ascent*, trans. Colm Luibheid and Norman Russell (Paulist Press)
- Isaac the Syrian, *Ascetical Homilies*, trans. Sebastian Brock (CSCO, 1987)
- John of Damascus, *Exposition of the Orthodox Faith*, trans. Frederick H. Chase (Fathers of the Church)

Byzantine Mysticism

- Symeon the New Theologian, *Hymns of Divine Love*, trans. George Maloney (Paulist Press)
- Gregory Palamas, *The Triads*, trans. Nicholas Gendle (Paulist Press)
- *The Philokalia*, Vols. 1–4, eds. G.E.H. Palmer, Philip Sherrard, and Kallistos Ware (Faber & Faber)
- Alexander Schmemmann, *For the Life of the World* (St. Vladimir's Seminary Press, 1973)

Latin Fathers and Early Medieval Theology

- Augustine, *Confessions*, trans. Henry Chadwick (Oxford World's Classics)
- John Scotus Eriugena, *Periphyseon*, trans. I.P. Sheldon-Williams (Irish Texts Society)
- Anselm of Canterbury, *Proslogion and Monologion*, trans. Thomas Williams (Hackett, 2007)
- Hugh of St. Victor, *Didascalicon*, trans. Jerome Taylor (Columbia UP, 1961)
- Richard of St. Victor, *Benjamin Major (On Contemplation)*, trans. Clare Kirchberger (SPCK, 1957)
- Bernard of Clairvaux, *On Loving God*, trans. Robert Walton (Cistercian Publications)

High Medieval Scholastic & Mystical Theology

- Bonaventure, *The Journey of the Mind to God (Itinerarium Mentis in Deum)*, trans. Philotheus Boehner (Hackett, 1956)

- Thomas Aquinas, *Summa Theologiae*, trans. Fathers of the English Dominican Province (Blackfriars / New Advent)
- Meister Eckhart, *Selected Writings*, trans. Oliver Davies (Penguin Classics)
- *The Cloud of Unknowing and Other Works*, trans. A.C. Spearing (Penguin Classics)
- Julian of Norwich, *Revelations of Divine Love*, trans. Elizabeth Spearing (Penguin Classics)
- Catherine of Siena, *The Dialogue*, trans. Suzanne Noffke (Paulist Press)
- Thomas à Kempis, *The Imitation of Christ*, trans. Aloysius Croft (Dover, 2003)

Early Modern Mystics and Renewal

- Teresa of Ávila, *Interior Castle*, trans. E. Allison Peers (Dover)
- John of the Cross, *Dark Night of the Soul* and *Ascent of Mount Carmel*, trans. E. Allison Peers (Image Books)
- Francis de Sales, *Treatise on the Love of God*, trans. John K. Ryan (Tan Books)
- Seraphim of Sarov, *Conversation with Motovilov* (St. Herman Press)
- Nicodemus the Hagiorite, *Unseen Warfare*, trans. Nicodemus / Scupoli (St. Vladimir's Seminary Press)
- Blaise Pascal, *Pensées*, trans. Roger Ariew (Hackett)
- St. Nicetas Stethatos, *On the Practice of the Virtues* (Philokalia selections)

Modern and Contemporary Theologians

- Thérèse of Lisieux, *Story of a Soul*, trans. John Clarke (ICS Publications)
 - Edith Stein, *The Science of the Cross*, trans. Josephine Koeppel (ICS Publications)
 - Silouan the Athonite, *Writings*, trans. Archimandrite Sophrony (St. Vladimir's Press)
 - Henri de Lubac, *Catholicism: Christ and the Common Destiny of Man* (Ignatius Press)
 - Vladimir Lossky, *The Mystical Theology of the Eastern Church* (St. Vladimir's Seminary Press)
 - Thomas Merton, *New Seeds of Contemplation* (New Directions)
 - Olivier Clément, *The Roots of Christian Mysticism* (New City Press)
 - Pope John Paul II, *Crossing the Threshold of Hope* (Knopf)
 - Jean Corbon, *The Wellspring of Worship* (Ignatius Press)
 - Dumitru Stăniloae, *Orthodox Dogmatic Theology*, Vol. 1 (Holy Cross Press)
 - Hans Urs von Balthasar, *The Glory of the Lord*, Vol. 1 (Ignatius Press)
 - David Bentley Hart, *The Beauty of the Infinite* (Eerdmans)
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II. PHILOSOPHICAL AND CLASSICAL SOURCES

Greek Philosophy and Plato

- Plato, *Complete Works*, ed. John M. Cooper (Hackett)
 - *Phaedrus*, *Symposium*, *Republic* VI–VII, *Timaeus*, *Philebus*, *Parmenides*, *Theaetetus*, *Phaedo*, *Laws* X
- Aristotle, *Complete Works*, ed. Jonathan Barnes (Princeton)
 - *Metaphysics* (esp. I, V, IX, XII), *Nicomachean Ethics* X, *De Anima* III, *Posterior Analytics* II, *Politics* I
- Philo of Alexandria, *On the Creation of the World*, trans. C.D. Yonge (Dover)
- Alcinous, *Didaskalikos (Handbook of Platonism)*, trans. Dillon (Clarendon Press)
- Plotinus, *The Enneads*, trans. A.H. Armstrong (Loeb Classical Library)
- Porphyry, *Life of Plotinus*, trans. MacKenna (Harvard UP)
- Iamblichus, *On the Mysteries*, trans. Clarke, Dillon, Hershbelle (SBL)
- Proclus, *The Elements of Theology*, trans. E.R. Dodds (Clarendon Press)
- Boethius, *The Consolation of Philosophy*, trans. V.E. Watts (Penguin)
- Augustine, *On the Trinity*, trans. Stephen McKenna (Catholic UP)

Jewish and Islamic Philosophy (Contextual)

- Maimonides, *The Guide for the Perplexed*, trans. Shlomo Pines (Chicago)
- Avicenna (Ibn Sina), *Metaphysics of the Healing*, trans. Marmura (BYU Press)
- Averroes (Ibn Rushd), *Long Commentary on De Anima*, trans. Taylor (Yale UP)

III. HISTORICAL AND SECONDARY SOURCES

General Church History

- Henry Chadwick, *The Early Church* (Penguin)
- Jaroslav Pelikan, *The Christian Tradition*, Vols. 1–5 (Chicago)
- Robert Markus, *The End of Ancient Christianity* (Cambridge)
- Philip Sherrard, *The Greek East and the Latin West* (Oxford)
- Diarmaid MacCulloch, *A History of Christianity* (Viking)

Patristic and Byzantine Studies

- Andrew Louth, *The Origins of the Christian Mystical Tradition* (Oxford)
- John Meyendorff, *Byzantine Theology* (Fordham)
- John Meyendorff, *A Study of Gregory Palamas* (St. Vladimir's Press)

- Sebastian Brock, *The Syriac Fathers on Prayer and the Spiritual Life* (Cistercian)
- Alexander Schmemmann, *Introduction to Liturgical Theology* (St. Vladimir's Press)
- Kallistos Ware, *The Orthodox Way* (St. Vladimir's Press)
- Georges Florovsky, *Ways of Russian Theology*, Vols. 1–2 (Nordland)

Medieval & Scholastic Theology

- Jean Leclercq, *The Love of Learning and the Desire for God* (Fordham)
- Bernard McGinn, *The Presence of God: A History of Western Christian Mysticism* (5 vols., Crossroad)
- Étienne Gilson, *The Spirit of Medieval Philosophy* (Scribner)
- Louis Bouyer, *The Meaning of the Monastic Life* (Burns & Oates)
- Zachary Hayes, *Bonaventure: Mystical Theologian* (Franciscan Institute)
- Denys Turner, *Thomas Aquinas: Theologian* (Yale)
- Bernard McGinn, *The Mystical Thought of Meister Eckhart* (Crossroad)

Reformation and Early Modern Mysticism

- E. Allison Peers, *Spirit of Flame: The Life of St. John of the Cross* (SPCK)
- Rowan Williams, *Teresa of Ávila* (Continuum)
- Wendy Wright, *Heart Speaks to Heart: The Salesian Tradition* (Orbis)
- Louis Dupré, *The Enlightenment and the Intellectual Foundations of Modern Culture* (Yale)

Modern and Contemporary Theology

- Hans Urs von Balthasar, *The Glory of the Lord* (Ignatius Press)
 - Henri de Lubac, *Catholicism* (Ignatius)
 - Vladimir Lossky, *The Mystical Theology of the Eastern Church* (St. Vladimir's Press)
 - Olivier Clément, *The Roots of Christian Mysticism* (New City Press)
 - Dumitru Stăniloae, *Orthodox Dogmatic Theology* (Holy Cross)
 - Thomas Merton, *New Seeds of Contemplation* (New Directions)
 - Sarah Coakley, *God, Sexuality and the Self* (Cambridge)
 - Aidan Nichols, *Rome and the Eastern Churches* (Ignatius)
 - Robert Taft, *Beyond East and West* (Pontifical Oriental Institute)
 - Karen Kilby, *Balthasar: A (Very) Critical Introduction* (Eerdmans)
 - David Bentley Hart, *The Experience of God: Being, Consciousness, Bliss* (Yale)
 - Andrew Louth, *Modern Orthodox Thinkers* (SPCK)
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IV. SUPPLEMENTARY / REFERENCE

- *The Oxford Dictionary of the Christian Church*, eds. F.L. Cross & E.A. Livingstone
 - *Cambridge History of Christianity*, vols. 1–9 (Cambridge UP)
 - *The Routledge Companion to Early Christian Thought*, ed. D. Ferguson
 - *Encyclopedia of Christian Theology*, ed. Jean-Yves Lacoste
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V. Recommended Reading Sequences (Optional)

Focus	Key Works
Patristic Mysticism	Louth, <i>Origins</i> → Dionysius, <i>Mystical Theology</i> → Gregory of Nyssa, <i>Life of Moses</i>
Scholastic and Medieval Synthesis	Anselm, <i>Proslogion</i> → Aquinas, <i>Summa</i> → Bonaventure, <i>Itinerarium</i>
Byzantine Theosis	Maximus, <i>Ambigua</i> → Palamas, <i>Triads</i> → Lossky, <i>Mystical Theology</i>
Western Mystical Path	Bernard, <i>On Loving God</i> → Eckhart, <i>Sermons</i> → John of the Cross, <i>Dark Night</i>
Modern Renewal	de Lubac, <i>Catholicism</i> → Balthasar, <i>Glory of the Lord</i> → Hart, <i>Beauty of the Infinite</i>
